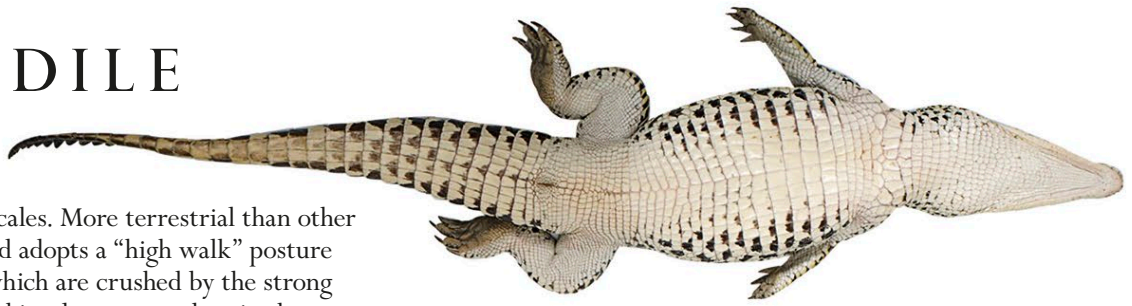


CUBAN CROCODILE

Crocodylus rhombifer

This strikingly coloured crocodile is native to Cuba.

It is medium-sized, robust, and armoured with bony scales. More terrestrial than other crocodilian species, it raises its belly off the ground and adopts a “high walk” posture when moving on land. Its preferred prey are turtles, which are crushed by the strong teeth at the rear of its mouth. Hunting pressure and habitat loss meant that, in the 1960s, the few remaining wild Cuban crocodiles were captured and released into Zapata Swamp, a reserve in the south of the island. Although protected, the population remains small, and hybridization with American crocodiles on the reserve threatens the purity of this species.



SIZE 3–3.5 m (9¼–11 ft)
HABITAT Freshwater swamps
DISTRIBUTION Cuba
DIET Fish, turtles, small mammals

large scales armoured
with bony deposits

bony projections at
back of the head
resemble horns

external ear flap,
which is closed while the
crocodile is under water

